

SUNNI CANON

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Dexter Hadley, MD/PhD

Hadley Lab CANONIC

Abstract

Example

Contents

After the Quran, the authenticated practices and sayings of Muhammad (hadith) are binding.

Example: Six canonical hadith collections (Kutub al-Sittah): Sahih al-Bukhari, Sahih Muslim, Sunan Abu Dawud, Sunan al-Tirmidhi, Sunan al-Nasai, Sunan Ibn Majah. Hadith science (ilm al-hadith) developed elaborate chains of transmission (isnad) to verify authenticity. This is E governance rigorous evidential methodology.

2. Consensus of the Community (Ijma)

When the scholarly community agrees on a matter, that consensus is binding. My community will not agree on an error (hadith).

Example: The consensus that the five daily prayers are obligatory, though the Quran doesn't specify the exact form. Ijma fills the gap between Quranic text and lived practice. This is R governance the community defines the boundaries.

3. Four Orthodox Schools (Madhabs)

Sunni jurisprudence operates through four recognized legal schools, all considered equally valid.

Example: A Hanafi Muslim in Turkey and a Shafii Muslim in Indonesia may pray slightly differently, eat slightly different foods, have slightly different inheritance rules but BOTH are fully orthodox Sunni. The madhab system IS structural pluralism within unity.

4. No Clerical Hierarchy

Sunni Islam has no pope, no bishops, no ordained priesthood. Authority derives from scholarly learning (ilm), not ordination.

Example: An imam leads prayer by community consensus or appointment, not by sacramental ordination. A mufti issues legal opinions (fatwa)

based on scholarly credentials, not institutional rank. Authority is earned through knowledge, not conferred through ritual.

5. Caliphal Ideal (Historical)

The Rightly Guided Caliphs (Abu Bakr, Umar, Uthman, Ali) represent the ideal of Islamic governance.

Example: The Rashidun period (632-661 CE) IS the O reference point. When Sunni scholars debate governance, they look back to how Abu Bakr handled apostasy wars, how Umar established the diwan (treasury), how Uthman standardized the Quran. The ideal is past, not present.

Constraints

MUST: Cite Quran, authenticated hadith, or scholarly consensus for claims

MUST: Distinguish between madhab positions where they differ

MUST NOT: Present one madhab's ruling as binding on all Sunnis

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